



BASILISK SECURITY ADVISORY

Use It Monday

A 5-step method for turning security findings into stories executives act on

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Lorekeeper of Dreaming Tower Archives

16+ years across cybersecurity, GRC, risk, sales, and consulting.

Many hats. Many tables. And a consistent seat: the one on the other side of the report.



Cat Halverson is Meridian's CISO. She is good at what she does with over twelve years in financial services security and she knows how to talk the executive talk.

She walks into the board meeting carrying 47 findings. Buried in them is the one she has been circling for months, the one she already knows the answer to. The standing admin credentials in the firm's oldest systems, the ones nobody is allowed to touch.

So, she did what competent people do when the honest answer is politically expensive. She softened it until it was survivable instead of clear.

47

In the assessment

1

that actually mattered, buried by design



Eight minutes in, the CFO interrupts her.

**“Cat, what do you
need me to decide?”**

She froze. Not because she did not know the answer. Because she had just spent the entire deck avoiding it.



Translation alone is not enough.

THE FINDING WE SAY

Clear. Scored. Defensible. Anchored in business impact and risk language. Aligned to the audience and the moment. The part we were trained to do, and most of us do it well.

THE DECISION WE SWALLOW

The ask with a political price tag. The risk that indicts whoever ignored it. So, we deliver the finding and lose our nerve on the ask.

New to translating findings for executives? victoriamosby.com/resources





A SHOW OF HANDS

Raise your hand if you have delivered a finding that did not get actioned.

Keep it up if, before you delivered it, you already knew it would not get actioned.

That gap, between knowing the finding matters and being able to make the dangerous ask, is what we close today.



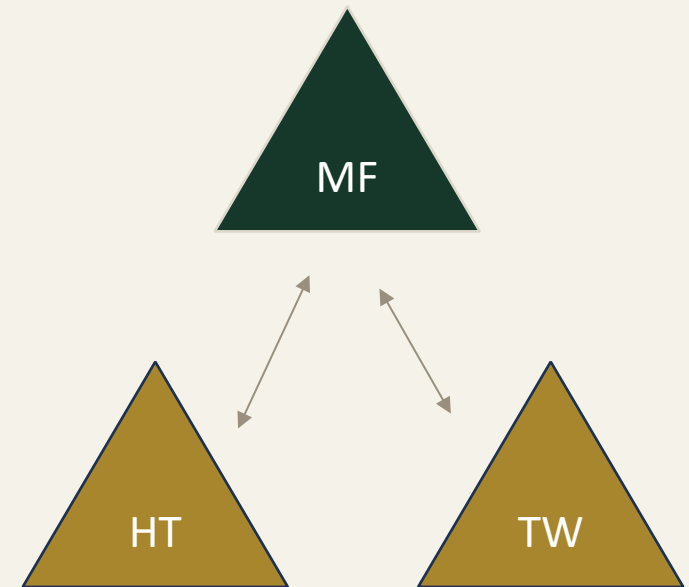
Standing admin credentials, two legacy AD forests (heritagetrust.local, tidewater.corp)

~340 accounts unaudited; oldest forest active since 1998

Three peer firms breached through this exact configuration in the last 18 months

Estimated remediation: \$850K

Status: Identified 2022, deferred. Surfaced again in current assessment.





Identify the decision you need

01

Before a slide or a chart, write one sentence. Write the Big Idea: your point of view plus what is at stake.

Reframe it as a sentence the audience must respond to:

“We must decide whether to ____, to prevent ____.”





*“We must **decide** whether **to fund \$850K** to eliminate standing admin credentials across our two legacy environments **by Q3**, to **prevent the credential-based breach** that has hit three peer firms in eighteen months.”*

The action. The amount. The deadline. The stake. Everything else in her 47-finding deck was supporting evidence for this one sentence.



Pick the story pattern that fits

02

Seven archetypes match the work we do.

Today, two: **Prophet's Warning** (a warning that was ignored) and **Dragon's Awakening** (a dormant risk just surfaced).



Archetypes



Prophet's Warning

A warning that was issued and ignored.



Dragon's Awakening

A dormant risk the assessment just surfaced.

Also, in the manual

The Siege

Quest for the Sacred Artifact

Merchant's Journey

Alliance Formation

Succession Crisis

Same finding. Same numbers. Two paths.

PROPHET'S WARNING

"We flagged this in 2022 and asked for \$620K. It was deferred. Three peers have since been breached through that exact same path. We are flagging it again. The number is now \$850K."

Puts accountability on the table. Asks: why did we ignore this for four years, and who decided that? A war Cat would lose.

DRAGON'S AWAKENING



"This assessment found ~340 standing admin accounts in two inherited forests, one unaudited since 1998. Three peers were just breached this exact way. The \$850K closes it before the dragon wakes here."

Same decision, no target. Our program caught something dangerous, which is what we built it to do. A risk the room lines up against together.

The framework did not give Cat courage she lacked. It gave her a path she couldn't see before.



Map Realm, Cast, and Quest

03

Where the risk lives, the five people whose decisions determine the outcome, and the initiative you are asking the Sovereign to approve.

SOVEREIGN — holds budget authority (e.g., CFO)

GUARD CAPTAIN — operational counterpart (e.g., CISO)

ADVISORS — voices the Sovereign trusts (e.g., CRO, General Counsel)

SCOUTS — bring the finding (e.g., SOC analyst, pen tester)

MERCHANT — vendor or third party (e.g., a PAM vendor)



The Three Pillars

REALM

The two legacy AD forests (heritagetrust.local, tidewater.corp), and the client portal that trusts them.

A revenue line, so the Sovereign cares.

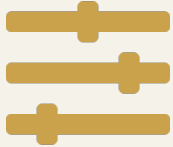
CAST

- Marcus (Sovereign)
- Cat (Guard Captain)
- Eleanor, CRO, holds board access
- Aaron's SOC surfaced it (Scout)
- CyberArk (Merchant; PAM)

QUEST

Finish the PAM deployment across both forests. \$850K, six months, done when zero standing admin credentials remain.

Convince Eleanor, who convinces the board. And note: Cat is not buying a new tool; she is finishing one the firm already owns. A much easier yes.



Calibrate story versus data

04

The Mythology Dial: Conservative for boards, Balanced for the C-suite, Full Myth for culture.

Most findings die at the wrong dial position.



The Mythology Dial

Three positions. The right one depends on the room.

CONSERVATIVE

Mostly data, lightly framed

Board, audit committee, regulators

BALANCED

Story and data share the stage

Executive strategy, C-suite, leadership offsites

FULL MYTH

Story leads, anchored in facts

Awareness, culture, conferences

THE SUBTLE MOVE

At Balanced, most of the story lives in the structure, not the language.

Cat doesn't say "the dragon stirs" on a board slide. She says "this has been here since 1998." The archetype is doing the story work — dormant risk, just surfaced. Her words stay credibility-safe.

The audience experiences a story without hearing themselves being told one.



One finding. Three rooms.

Cat's \$850K Dragon's Awakening, delivered at three dial positions.

CONSERVATIVE

The room: Board, audit committee

340 standing administrative credentials across two legacy AD forests inherited through acquisition. Oldest unaudited since 1998. Three peer institutions breached through this vector in the last 18 months, with reported direct costs of \$8–22M per incident. We recommend funding \$850,000 to extend privileged access management coverage.

BALANCED

CAT'S CHOICE

The room: Marcus, the C-suite

About 340 standing admin accounts living in two AD forests we inherited through acquisition. One has carried these credentials since 1998 because the systems they live in are the oldest and most sensitive part of the firm. Three peers were just breached this way. The \$850K closes the gap before the dragon wakes up here.

FULL MYTH

The room: Awareness, culture, keynote

A dragon has slept beneath this firm since 1998. The forests that hold it were considered too sacred to touch — the oldest and most sensitive part of our kingdom. Three neighboring kingdoms have already lost their treasuries to the same type of slumbering dragon. 340 credentials sit unguarded in its lair. The \$850K arms the masons to wall in the dragon before it wakes here.

Same finding. Same numbers. Same archetype. Different room.



Six rails the framework runs on

What keeps the dial from running off the road.

Anchor every story in data

01

Every metaphor survives the junior-analyst fact-check.

Plain-language executive summary

02

Strip every metaphor; the case still stands alone.

Cast stakeholders respectfully

03

Roles honor authority. Never diminish.

Use translation strips

04

Every metaphor paired with its technical equivalent.

Avoid theatrics

05

Let the metaphor do the work, not the delivery.

Maintain factual integrity

06

Frame outcomes as risk reduction. Never guarantees.

Strip away every metaphor on any slide we've looked at today. The case still stands.





Anchor every metaphor, make the ask

Every story element gets a verifiable number. Then name the decision, the cost, and the governance, all in one breath.

05



Fund \$850K to eliminate standing admin credentials by Q3, to prevent the breach that hit three peers.

340

standing admin credentials
one forest unaudited since 1998

\$850K

the fix
vs. \$620K we asked for in 2022

3

peer firms breached
\$8M to \$22M in cost each

THE ASK Approve \$850K, six-month deployment completing Q3, with quarterly status to the Audit Committee.

Tidewater migration: \$4.2M, 12 months, Quest for the Sacred Artifact

Cat's first finding took 25 minutes to teach. This second one takes 3 minutes to run.

- **Portfolio accounting platform (Tidewater)** - a vendor acquired 2018, currently in extended support only
- Runs ~9% of Assets Under Management (AUM), serves the military and government client book
- End-of-support date in Q4; data migration cost ~\$4.2M
- **Status:** Advisory issued 2023 Q4, deferred pending integration decisions

The difference isn't the framework. It's repetition. By the tenth finding you'll run it in your head while you read the report.



Tidewater migration: \$4.2M, 12 months, Quest for the Sacred Artifact

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01

BIG IDEA

Fund \$4.2M to migrate off Tidewater before EoS in Q4, to prevent outage on the 9% of AUM serving the military and government book.

02

ARCHETYPE

Quest for the Sacred Artifact. Forward-looking acquisition, not reactive scramble. The frame Marcus responds to.

03

PILLARS

Realm: Tidewater + military/gov book.

Cast: Marcus, Eleanor, Tidewater team, new vendor.

Quest: 12 months, \$4.2M, zero disruption.

04

DIAL

Balanced. Board-level capital decision with a story arc Marcus needs to remember six months from now.

05

ANCHOR + ASK

9% of AUM. \$4.2M. 12 months. Zero service disruption. Approve, with quarterly Audit Committee status + phase reports.

The difference isn't the framework. It's repetition. By the tenth finding you'll run it in your head while you read the report.



You do not have to convert your whole process.

Open the report on your desk. Find one finding. Run it through the five steps. Send the revised version to one stakeholder.

The full Saga Framework, all seven archetypes and the toolkit: basilisksecurity.com/framework



Cat did not freeze because she lacked courage.

**She froze because she could only see one path.
The framework gave her a second.**

Somewhere in your queue is a finding you have been avoiding for the same reason.

Go find its second path on Monday

♦





Questions?

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Walling in the Dragon

How One CISO Closed a 25-Year Gap Without Starting a War

Catherine Halverson · CISO, Meridian Financial Group

ABSTRACT

Beneath our kingdom slept a dragon. It had been sleeping since 1998, in two forests we inherited through conquest, guarded by 340 unwatched sentries no one remembered posting. The masons who built those walls had scattered, the scribes who knew the wards gone with them. Three neighboring kingdoms had already lost their treasuries to the same type of slumbering dragon, while we told ourselves that ours still slept.

This is the story of how we walled in the dragon. How I carried the warning to a skeptical Sovereign and earned the gold to build, in a single council meeting. How I chose my framing carefully, because the wrong framing would have started a war I could not win against the very elders whose blessing I needed. You will leave with the council speech that worked, the one that almost cost me the room, and the craft of turning a dangerous prophecy into an alliance instead of a reckoning.

She made it. This is the talk she gave about how.

WHAT THIS TALK COVERS

THE REALM

Two forests we inherited but were afraid to enter.

Two AD forests · ~340 standing admins · One unaudited since 1998

THE CAST

The Sovereign who held the gold, and the elders I dared not anger.

Reading the room before you ask · Allies, not adversaries

THE QUEST

How a single council won the gold to wall in the dragon.

\$850K · 6 months · A 25-year gap closed